ALGORITHMS THAT MANUFACTURE DESIRE: HOW SOCIAL MEDIA CURATION CO-PRODUCES LUXURY TASTE AMONG GENERATION Z

An Exploratory Experiment on Simulated Curated-Feed Exposure in a Predominantly Indian Sample of Gen Z Adults

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ABSTRACT

Much of the research on digital consumer culture holds that algorithmically curated social media shapes what Generation Z finds desirable and normal in luxury fashion. Most of that evidence is observational, which leaves open whether exposure changes taste or simply tracks the dispositions of people who already seek luxury content out. This study tests the short-run version of the claim with an experiment. Seventy-eight adults aged 18 to 28, recruited online, mostly female and mostly living in India, were each randomly assigned with a three-option digital spinner to one of three versions of a survey. Each version showed one simulated social media feed built by the researcher: one of two curated luxury fashion feeds (Conditions B and C) or a neutral everyday-content feed. Participants then completed a researcher-developed six-item taste-formation measure (α = .75) covering luxury aspiration, normalization, identification, and purchase intention. Composite scores did not differ detectably across conditions, $F(2, 75) = 0.13$, $p = .88$, and no single item differed. The pooled luxury-versus-neutral difference was −0.14 points on a 7-point scale, 95% CI [−0.67, 0.40], $d = -0.12$. A sensitivity analysis shows the study could reliably detect only effects of about $d = 0.67$ or larger, and one-sided equivalence testing rejects a luxury advantage of $d = 0.30$ or more but cannot rule out a small effect. An exploratory gender difference did not survive correction for multiple tests. In this sample, one brief exposure to curated luxury content produced no detectable shift in luxury taste. Because the feeds were static, and the platform algorithms that adapt to users over time were not tested, the results cannot speak to cumulative influence. Whether luxury taste forms through repeated exposure remains a hypothesis for longitudinal research.

Keywords: algorithmic curation; simulated social media feed; luxury fashion; taste formation; Generation Z; null result; equivalence testing

1. Introduction and Motivation

Generation Z has come of age inside an attention economy run by recommendation systems. For young people whose social lives unfold across Instagram, TikTok, and Pinterest, what appears on screen is a machine-selected stream optimized for engagement. A growing body of scholarship argues that these systems do more than reflect what users already want. They help construct desire and normalize particular aesthetics, shaping the symbolic vocabulary through which young consumers read status and taste (Lichtcsien, 2021; Park & Chun, 2025). The stakes are especially high in luxury fashion, where consumption is driven less by utility than by meaning and identity (Batamirova & Thrassou, 2025).

This paper tests the most immediate version of that claim. The question is deliberately narrow: does one brief exposure to a curated luxury feed change how young adults rate luxury aspiration, normalization,

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identification, and purchase intention? If it does, the shaping claim holds even at the scale of a single session. If it does not, the claim may still be right about influence that builds over months and years of use, but any such influence would have to come through repetition. Much of the existing evidence links long-run platform use to luxury attitudes, a design that cannot separate the effect of exposure from the dispositions of the people who seek that exposure out.

To separate the two, this study uses a randomized experiment, something the observational literature largely lacks. Seventy-eight adults aged 18 to 28 took part in 2026, all of them within the adult portion of Generation Z (Section 4.1 sets out the definition used). Participants were randomly assigned to view one of three simulated feeds built by the researcher, either one of two luxury fashion feeds or a neutral control, and then rated the feed on a six-item taste-formation measure. The feeds were fixed images. They showed the kind of content an algorithm might curate, but they did not adapt to the viewer, so the experiment tests exposure to curated luxury content and not the workings of a live recommendation algorithm. If the shaping claim held in its immediate form, the luxury conditions should have produced higher ratings than the neutral control. They did not. That null result is the core finding of this paper, and the sections that follow ask what it can and cannot tell us.

The motivation for pinning this down is both scholarly and practical. A field that assumes rather than tests the mechanism of taste formation risks mistaking a slow cultural process for an instant persuasive effect. Brands and regulators would also draw very different conclusions depending on whether a single sponsored feed can move aspiration or whether only sustained immersion can. Testing the single-exposure case narrows down where any influence is likely to operate, and leaves the cumulative case for future work.

2. Theoretical Framework: Taste, Algorithms, and Time

Three theoretical commitments structure this study. Each implies that taste is built slowly, so together they predict that a single brief exposure should do little. On this view, a null result from a one-session design is an expected outcome and not an anomaly to explain away.

2.1 Taste as a socially constructed disposition

Following Bourdieu (1984), taste is treated here as a durable disposition, a *habitus*, accumulated through repeated exposure to the aesthetic codes of a social field, and not as innate preference. On this view, taste is structural and sedimentary: it forms as people take in and reproduce the same signals across countless interactions. The key word is *durable*. A disposition acquired over years is unlikely to be rewritten by one exposure lasting a few minutes. The theory therefore predicts that single-session manipulations should have weak effects, and the results reported below are consistent with that prediction.

2.2 Algorithms as cultural gatekeepers

Recommendation systems act as what Striphas (2015) calls agents of “algorithmic culture”: they decide what becomes visible and, through repeated promotion, what becomes normal. The mechanism by which they shape taste is *repetition*. Lichtcsien (2021), interviewing fashion-focused Instagram users, finds that users knowingly train the platform’s algorithm through their engagement, and that the trained feed then becomes a tool for their fashion consumption. Park and Chun (2025) describe young consumers learning luxury through ongoing contact with influencer and peer content on social media. Both accounts are

iterative. The filter bubble (Pariser, 2011) and the recommendation loop do their work over many passes, so a theory whose core causal verb is "repeat" predicts little from a design that permits no repetition.

The present experiment cannot reproduce that loop. Its feeds were fixed, researcher-curated images that did not respond to participants' behavior. It isolates one ingredient of algorithmic curation, the content a curated feed puts in front of a user, and leaves aside the adaptive loop that personalizes the feed over time.

2.3 Luxury as symbolic consumption

Finally, luxury fashion is understood here as symbolic rather than functional consumption: its value lies in conveying status and belonging (Batamirova & Thrassou, 2025). Symbolic meaning is socially negotiated and learned, which means that perceiving a brand as prestigious is itself an acquired competence. One cannot install symbolic capital through a brief exposure any more than one can acquire a dialect by hearing a sentence. The symbolic frame thus converges with the other two: building luxury taste takes time.

Put together, these strands give the study its guiding proposition. If taste is a durable disposition (2.1), reinforced through algorithmic repetition (2.2), in a symbolic domain that has to be learned (2.3), then a single brief exposure to curated content should be too weak to move it. The experiment tests the immediate version of the shaping hypothesis against that expectation. It does not test the cumulative version, which would require repeated exposure over time.

3. Literature Review

The following review surveys existing scholarship on algorithmic exposure, influencer mediation, and symbolic luxury consumption. It sets out the dominant claim this study tests and shows how much of the field rests on observational, outcome-focused designs, the limitation that motivates the present experiment.

Scope of the Review

Recent scholarship increasingly recognizes that consumer preferences, particularly in luxury fashion, now take shape inside digitally mediated environments structured by algorithmic systems, alongside individual taste and traditional marketing. For Generation Z, whose social lives are deeply embedded in platforms such as Instagram, TikTok, and Pinterest, algorithmically curated content is widely argued to shape perceptions of desirability and status. This review synthesizes research across three interconnected themes: (1) algorithmic exposure and taste formation, (2) the role of influencers and peer networks in luxury consumption, and (3) symbolic identity construction in Gen Z consumer culture. Comparing these studies reveals a gap: scholars acknowledge both algorithmic influence and luxury symbolism, yet few examine directly how algorithms help produce luxury taste among Gen Z consumers.

Algorithmic Curation and Taste Formation

Several scholars argue that algorithms shape user preferences as well as reflecting them. Lichtcsien's (2021) interview study of fashion consumers on Instagram shows that users take part in a dynamic, reciprocal relationship with recommendation systems. Consumers "train" the algorithm through interaction strategies such as liking and saving particular content. This lets the algorithm become a tool of consumption, influencing what users repeatedly encounter and, in turn, what becomes normalized as

fashionable. Lichtcsien also finds that some users read algorithmic misalignments, recommendations that miss their taste, as signals of devalued fashion. Algorithms may therefore shape taste partly through what users learn to reject.

Similarly, Yussuf, Almostafa, and Öhrn Ibarra (2025) explore how algorithms and cultural memory shape Gen Z's engagement with nostalgic fashion aesthetics. Their findings suggest that taste is formed through continuous exposure to emotionally charged content, where cultural memory and identity are reinforced through repeated visuals of retro trends. This supports the broader argument that algorithms influence the symbolic frameworks through which young consumers interpret fashion, and not just purchasing behavior.

Park and Chun (2025) add qualitative evidence from interviews with 26 Korean consumers aged 14 to 24. Their participants describe luxury content from influencers and peers on social media as a direct driver of purchase decisions, and describe posting luxury items as a route to social approval and wider networks. Together, these studies portray algorithms, and the content they circulate, as cultural intermediaries that shape what young consumers see and plausibly what they come to want.

Influencers, Peers, and Social Validation in Luxury Consumption

While algorithms structure exposure, social actors within these platforms, particularly influencers and peers, mediate how luxury is interpreted. Sun et al. (2022) group social media influencers into four categories (celebrities, opinion leaders, friends and peers, and advertisers) and, in a survey of 400 Chinese Gen Z consumers analyzed with PLS-SEM, find that friends and peers exert the strongest influence on luxury fashion consumption. This finding challenges the assumption that celebrity influencers dominate and points to the importance of perceived authenticity and relatability.

Fadiora (2024) similarly finds that influencer attractiveness and perceived similarity significantly affect the fashion purchasing behavior of both Millennials and Gen Z. This fits the idea that fashion taste is socially constructed through identification, with consumers adopting preferences that align with people they relate to.

Symbolic Consumption, Identity, and Digital Luxury Culture

Beyond exposure and influence, luxury consumption among Gen Z is closely tied to identity construction. Batamirova and Thrassou (2025) argue that Gen Z is reshaping the luxury market around digital engagement and identity-driven consumption, and that brands reach this generation through digital influencers, augmented reality, and relatable communication. On their account, luxury for this generation is experienced as much through digital narrative as through the product itself.

Nallasivam et al. (2025), surveying 205 respondents in India, use machine learning models to predict luxury purchase intention from Instagram marketing. Psychological drivers such as prestige, uniqueness, and brand trust, along with personalized recommendations, emerged as the strongest predictors, while surface-level engagement metrics predicted little. Their Indian sample makes the study especially relevant to the present one.

What unites these studies is the recognition that luxury fashion functions as symbolic capital. Consumption is driven by meaning and perceived status at least as much as by utility. Yet while these studies acknowledge the power of digital platforms, many stop short of theorizing how algorithmic systems actively construct the symbolic field in which taste emerges.

Evaluation and Research Gap

Collectively, the literature offers three key insights. First, algorithms shape exposure patterns that influence what consumers repeatedly see and internalize as desirable (Lichtcsien, 2021; Park & Chun, 2025; Yussuf et al., 2025). Second, peers and influencers mediate this exposure by adding social validation and relatability (Sun et al., 2022; Fadiora, 2024). Third, luxury consumption among Gen Z is tied to identity formation and symbolic meaning within digital culture (Batamirova & Thrassou, 2025; Nallasivam et al., 2025).

The evidence behind these insights is largely observational. Studies report associations between influencer characteristics and purchase behavior (Sun et al., 2022; Fadiora, 2024), link responses to Instagram marketing with luxury purchase intention (Nallasivam et al., 2025), and describe through interviews how young people learn luxury on social media (Park & Chun, 2025; Lichtcsien, 2021). These findings establish that digital environments matter. They often stop short of the mechanisms through which influence occurs, and much of the research treats algorithms as background or focuses on marketing outcomes such as purchase intention, engagement, and brand loyalty.

A key limitation across much of the current scholarship is its focus on outcomes rather than processes. Many studies ask whether algorithms influence behavior, measuring variables such as engagement, loyalty, or purchase intention, but offer limited insight into how algorithmic systems take part in shaping taste itself. Quantitative models such as PLS-SEM (Sun et al., 2022) and machine learning prediction frameworks (Nallasivam et al., 2025) are valuable for demonstrating statistical relationships, yet they treat taste as a dependent variable and not as a socially and culturally constructed process. As a result, taste formation is often assumed rather than theorized.

Several studies also treat users primarily as passive recipients of algorithmic influence, particularly within marketing-focused research. Survey-based studies measure responses to content but say little about how individuals interpret, resist, or internalize what they encounter. Lichtcsien's (2021) work is a notable exception, as it recognizes a reciprocal relationship in which users strategically engage with algorithms. That insight remains underdeveloped in the luxury fashion context, where identity, aspiration, and symbolic meaning are central.

There is also a conceptual gap between algorithmic theory and luxury consumption theory. Research on algorithms and cultural curation (exposure repetition, recommendation loops, digital visibility) tends to exist separately from scholarship on luxury as symbolic consumption, identity performance, and cultural capital. Batamirova and Thrassou (2025) acknowledge that Gen Z's engagement with luxury is shaped by digital communication and platform dynamics, but they do not explicitly analyze algorithms as cultural actors that shape what counts as prestigious, stylish, or desirable in the first place.

As a result, the field lacks an integrated framework explaining how algorithmic systems, social validation mechanisms (likes, influencers, peer approval), and symbolic luxury meaning work together to construct taste over time. This gap matters most for Generation Z, whose aesthetic preferences form largely within algorithmically curated environments. Without addressing the mechanisms of taste formation, existing research risks reducing a complex cultural process to a narrow marketing effect.

Accordingly, this study asks a narrow question about how that influence operates: can it work through a single brief exposure to curated luxury content, or would it have to build over time? Testing the single-exposure case directly is a first step toward moving the discussion from correlation toward explanation.

Summary

The literature reviewed here shows a growing consensus that social media platforms, through recommendation systems and influencer ecosystems, are central to Gen Z luxury consumption. The deeper process of taste formation, how users come to perceive certain aesthetics as inherently desirable, remains underexplored, and the field's causal claims rest mostly on observational designs.

Bridging to the present study. The review makes the field's central claim explicit and, in doing so, exposes its evidentiary soft spot: the influence of algorithms on luxury taste is inferred almost entirely from observational designs, whether surveys (Nallasivam et al., 2025; Sun et al., 2022) or interviews (Park & Chun, 2025). Such designs cannot rule out that heavy users simply arrive with stronger luxury dispositions. The experiment reported below adds the missing counterfactual, random assignment to a controlled exposure, and uses it to ask whether the immediate version of the shaping claim holds. In this sample it did not, which leaves the cumulative version as the open question for future research.

4. Research Design and Methods

To learn whether a single exposure to curated luxury content shapes taste, everything else has to be held constant while only the feed varies, which observational designs cannot do. This study therefore uses a randomized, between-subjects experiment with a neutral control condition.

4.1 Participants

Seventy-eight adults aged 18 to 28 completed the study in 2026. Generation Z is defined following the Pew Research Center, which places the cohort's first birth year at 1997 (Dimock, 2019). Every participant was therefore born between roughly 1997 and 2008 and falls within the cohort. Because Generation Z also includes people born into the early 2010s, who were under 18 when the data were collected, the sample represents only the cohort's adult members.

Participants were recruited online through social media and school networks. The sample skewed female (n = 53, 68%), with male (n = 15), non-binary or third-gender (n = 8), and undisclosed (n = 2) respondents also represented, and most participants lived in India. All participants reported at least some familiarity with luxury fashion brands, and most reported daily or near-daily use of Instagram, WhatsApp, or Pinterest. This is a small convenience sample of digitally active young adults, mostly Indian and mostly female. It is not representative of Generation Z as a whole, and the findings apply most directly to people like those in it.

4.2 Design, randomization, and exposure

Three versions of the same Google Form were created. They were identical except for the feed image shown on the exposure page:

- Condition B (Luxury Feed B, n = 25): a researcher-curated feed of luxury fashion content, styled to resemble a social media feed.
- Condition C (Luxury Feed C, n = 25): a second, independently curated luxury fashion feed, included to test whether any luxury effect holds across different curations instead of depending on one particular feed.
- Neutral Feed (control, n = 28): a feed of everyday, non-luxury content matched in format but without luxury signals, serving as the counterfactual baseline.

Allocation. Before sending the survey link to each prospective participant, the researcher spun Google's built-in random spinner, set to three equally likely outcomes, and sent that person the link to whichever form version it selected. Each participant was assigned independently, which is why the groups ended up slightly unequal in size. Participants received only their own link. Neither the form nor the recruitment message mentioned that other versions existed, so participants did not know there were other conditions or which one they were in. The researcher generated the allocation and was therefore not blind to condition, but responses were collected anonymously through the form and scored identically across versions.

Procedure and exposure. Each form opened with a short statement describing an anonymous academic study of about four to five minutes in which participants would see a simulated social media feed. Participants first answered demographic and platform-use questions and the two baseline items described in Section 4.3. The next page showed the feed as a single tall image designed to look like a scrollable social media feed, with the instruction "Please scroll through and look at the posts in the image below." Viewing was self-paced. The form set no minimum or maximum viewing time and did not record how long participants stayed on the page, so exposure duration was not standardized and may have varied between participants. The outcome items followed on the next page.

The feeds were static images assembled by the researcher. They did not adapt to participants' behavior, and no recommendation algorithm was involved. The manipulation is therefore exposure to curated luxury content of the kind an algorithmic feed might deliver, and throughout this paper "luxury-feed exposure" refers to this simulated, curated exposure.

Including two distinct luxury feeds guards against concluding "no effect" from a single weak stimulus: if luxury exposure shaped taste, both B and C should exceed the neutral control. The study did not include a manipulation check, so it cannot directly confirm that participants saw the luxury feeds as more luxury-oriented than the neutral feed. The feeds were designed to differ sharply in content, luxury fashion against everyday imagery, but whether participants perceived the difference as intended was not measured (see Section 7).

4.3 Measures

Before exposure, participants answered two baseline items: general luxury interest ("On a scale of 1 to 7, how interested are you in luxury fashion?"; 1 = not interested, 7 = extremely interested) and baseline desirability ("Before seeing the next page, how desirable do you find luxury brands in general?"; 1 = not desirable at all, 7 = extremely desirable). The form also asked how often participants think about or follow luxury brands on social media; that item was not analyzed.

After exposure, participants rated the six statements shown in Table 1. The items were written for this study to cover the facets of luxury taste emphasized in the literature reviewed above. On the form they used a 7-point scale anchored 1 = strongly agree and 7 = strongly disagree, the reverse of the baseline items. All six were reverse-scored before analysis, so in every result reported here a higher score means stronger agreement.

Item	Wording	Refers to
1. Aspirational	The brands and styles shown in the feed feel aspirational to me	The feed
2. Normalized	Luxury fashion feels normal among people my age after seeing that feed	Luxury
3. Identify with	I can identify with the style and lifestyle shown in the feed	The feed
4. Purchase intent	I would consider purchasing or aspiring toward the brands/styles shown in the feed	The feed
5. Feels achievable	Seeing that feed made luxury consumption feel more achievable for someone like me	Luxury
6. “People like me” own it	The content made me feel like luxury items are something people like me own or use	Luxury

Table 1. The six taste-formation items as worded on the form. Items were reverse-scored before analysis so that higher values indicate stronger agreement.

The six items were averaged into a composite taste-formation score. The rationale for combining them is that each captures one facet of a single underlying response: how far the luxury lifestyle on screen registers as desirable and within reach for someone like the respondent. The items showed acceptable internal consistency (Cronbach’s $\alpha = .75$), but alpha alone does not show that they measure one construct, and the items are conceptually distinct. They also differ in what they refer to. Three of them (aspirational, identify with, purchase intent) ask about whatever “the feed” showed, so for the neutral group they refer to everyday content. The other three (normalized, feels achievable, “people like me” own it) ask about luxury directly in every condition. For these reasons the results report each item and the two three-item clusters alongside the composite (Section 5.3).

4.4 Analytic strategy

Analysis proceeded in four steps. First, a one-way ANOVA compared the composite across all three conditions, complemented by a planned contrast of the pooled luxury conditions against the neutral control (B and C combined versus neutral), reported with Cohen’s d and a 95% confidence interval. Second, parallel ANOVAs on each of the six items checked whether any single facet of taste responded to exposure even if the composite did not. Third, pre-exposure luxury interest was correlated with the composite and entered alongside condition in an ordinary least squares regression, to see whether prior interest predicted post-exposure ratings. Baseline equivalence across conditions was checked before interpreting any treatment contrast.

Fourth, because a non-significant result cannot by itself show that an effect is absent, two further analyses assess what the data can rule out. A sensitivity power analysis (two-tailed, $\alpha = .05$, 80% power) identifies the smallest effect the planned contrast could reliably detect with the achieved group sizes of 50 and 28 (Cohen, 1988). An equivalence test using the two one-sided tests procedure (TOST; Lakens, 2017) then asks which effect sizes the data can reject. Both analyses were conducted after data collection, from the

reported means, standard deviations, and confidence interval, in Python with the statsmodels and SciPy libraries.

Finally, composite scores were compared across gender groups as a secondary, exploratory analysis outside the experimental question. The paper reports seven secondary tests in total (the six item-level ANOVAs and the gender comparison), so these are also judged against a Bonferroni-corrected threshold of $\alpha = .05/7 \approx .007$.

Ethics. The study was conducted within the Lumiere Research Scholar Program, and its design and materials were reviewed by the program mentor. It was not reviewed by a formal institutional review board or ethics committee. Participation was voluntary and anonymous. The form's opening statement explained the study's purpose, its expected length, and the anonymity of responses; there was no separate consent item, and submitting the form was taken as consent to participate. The form collected no names or contact details, and responses were saved only on submission, so participants could withdraw at any point by closing the form. Every question except a final optional comment box was required, so participants who chose to continue could not skip individual items. The stimuli were ordinary fashion and lifestyle images, and participants were told in advance that the feed was simulated, so no deception was involved. The study presented no more than minimal risk.

All 78 respondents reported ages between 18 and 28, so no data from minors were collected or analyzed, and parental consent and minor assent procedures did not apply. The form did not include an explicit age screen, however. That gap is acknowledged in Section 7, and any future data collection should add both an eligibility screen and an explicit consent item.

5. Results

No analysis detected an effect of a single exposure to a curated luxury feed relative to a neutral feed. This section sets out that evidence and then examines how large an effect the data can and cannot rule out.

5.1 Baseline equivalence

Before interpreting any exposure effect, the three groups were checked for pre-existing differences. Pre-exposure luxury interest did not differ across conditions, $F(2, 75) = 0.07$, $p = .93$. Baseline desirability showed a non-significant trend, $F(2, 75) = 2.52$, $p = .087$, driven mainly by Luxury Feed C, which started highest, while the neutral group started lowest (Figure 1). If baseline desirability carried over into post-exposure ratings, this imbalance would favor the luxury conditions, and C in particular. Yet C finished with the lowest composite of the three groups, and the neutral group, which started lowest, finished highest. The imbalance therefore worked against the null result and cannot account for it.

5.2 The central result: no detectable effect of luxury-feed exposure

On the composite, the two luxury conditions were statistically indistinguishable from the neutral control. Luxury Feed B scored $M = 3.17$ ($SD = 1.15$), Luxury Feed C scored $M = 3.15$ ($SD = 1.15$), and the neutral feed scored slightly higher at $M = 3.29$ ($SD = 1.12$). A one-way ANOVA found no detectable difference among the three groups, $F(2, 75) = 0.13$, $p = .88$ (Figure 2). The planned treatment-versus-control contrast told the same story: pooling the luxury conditions gave a composite of $M = 3.16$ against the control's $M = 3.29$, a difference of -0.14 points on a 7-point scale, 95% CI $[-0.67, 0.40]$, $d = -0.12$. The point estimate runs slightly against the shaping hypothesis. The interval is wide, though. It spans zero and

includes differences of about half a scale point in either direction, so this contrast alone cannot rule out a modest effect (Section 5.5).

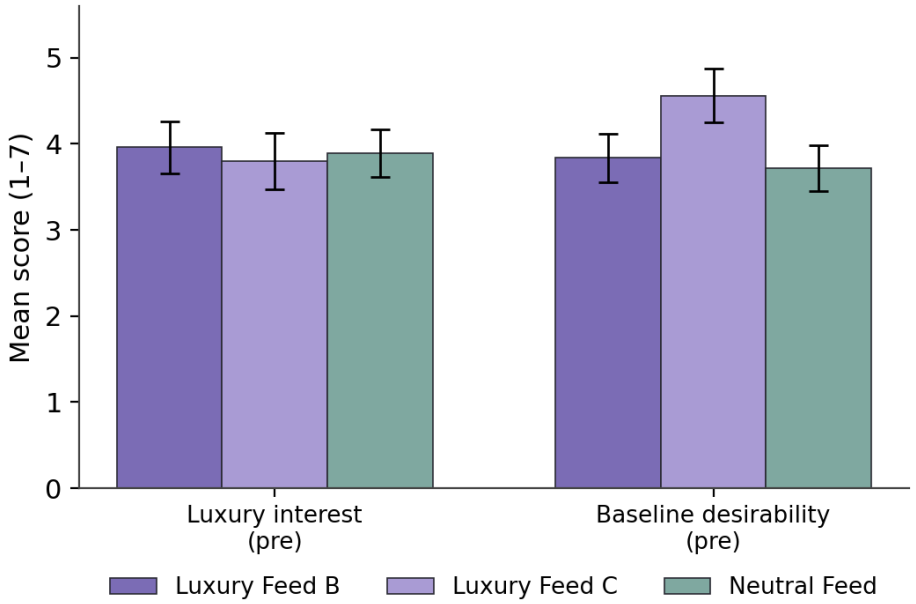


Figure 1. Pre-exposure luxury interest and baseline desirability by condition. Interest did not differ across conditions, F(2, 75) = 0.07, p = .93. Desirability showed a non-significant trend, F(2, 75) = 2.52, p = .087, with Luxury Feed C highest and the neutral feed lowest.

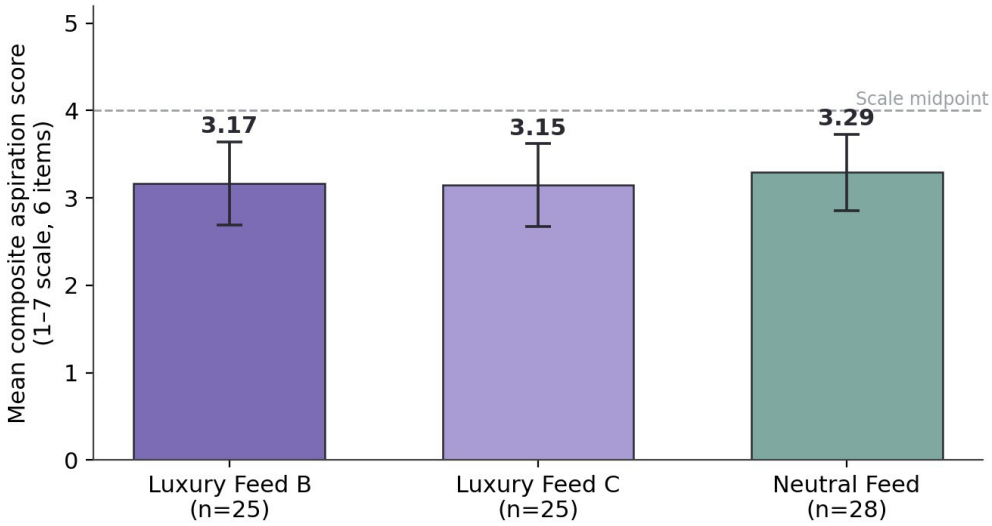


Figure 2. Mean composite score by condition, with 95% confidence intervals. One-way ANOVA: F(2, 75) = 0.13, p = .88. Pooled luxury versus neutral: −0.14 points, 95% CI [−0.67, 0.40].

Table 2 summarizes the condition means for each item, the composite, and the two item clusters. The values sit close together across feeds that differed sharply in content.

5.3 Item-level analysis

A composite null can sometimes mask offsetting effects on individual items. That did not happen here. Separate one-way ANOVAs on the six items found no significant differences across conditions, with *p*-values ranging from .10 to .92 (Figure 3). The two items that came closest, perceived normalization ($p = .12$) and "people like me" ownership ($p = .10$), did not favor the luxury feeds in any consistent way. On normalization, Luxury Feed C scored below the neutral control, and on "people like me" ownership, Luxury Feed B scored lowest of the three groups.

Measure	**Luxury B (n = 25)**	**Luxury C (n = 25)**	**Neutral (n = 28)**
Aspirational	3.28	3.08	3.54
Normalized	3.80	2.92	3.32
Identify with	3.12	2.96	3.11
Purchase intent	3.20	3.00	3.50
Feels achievable	3.20	3.48	2.96
"People like me" own it	2.40	3.44	3.32
Composite (α = .75)	3.17	3.15	3.29
Feed-referenced items (1, 3, 4)	3.20	3.01	3.38
Luxury-referenced items (2, 5, 6)	3.13	3.28	3.20

Table 2. Mean scores (1 to 7, higher = stronger agreement) by condition. No item differed significantly across conditions. Cluster means are averages of the item means and are descriptive.

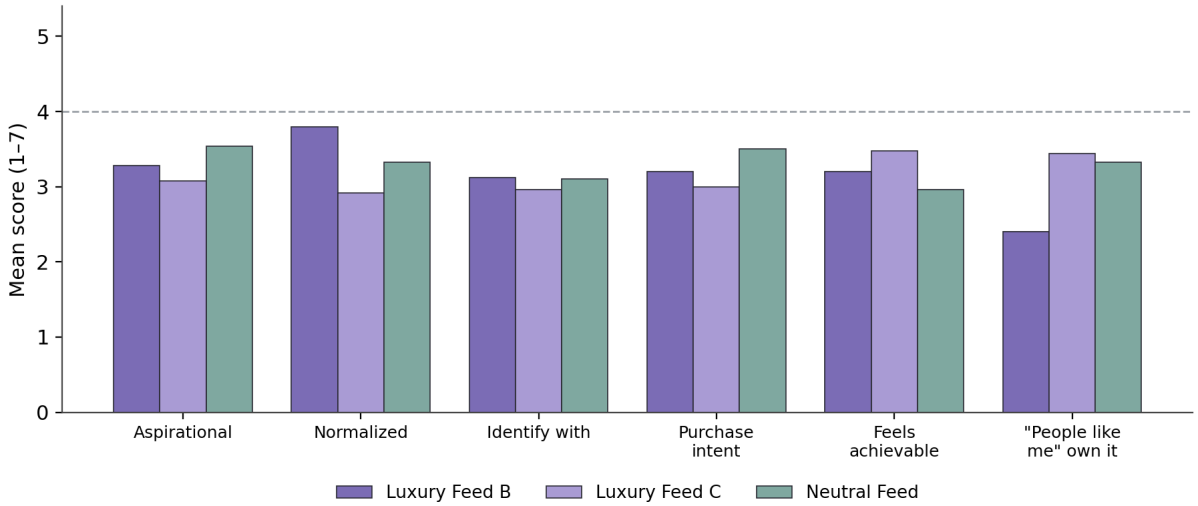


Figure 3. Mean score on each taste-formation item by condition. None of the six item-level ANOVAs was significant (p = .10 to .92), and the two closest items did not favor the luxury feeds.

Grouping the items by what they refer to shows where the small negative point estimate comes from. On the three luxury-referenced items, which ask about luxury in every condition, the groups were almost identical (B = 3.13, C = 3.28, neutral = 3.20). On the three feed-referenced items, which ask about

whatever the feed showed, the neutral group scored somewhat higher (B = 3.20, C = 3.01, neutral = 3.38). Participants who saw everyday content, in other words, rated that content as slightly more aspirational, relatable, and worth buying than participants who saw luxury content rated theirs. The slight negative tilt in the composite therefore seems to reflect reactions to different feed content, not a negative effect of luxury exposure on luxury attitudes. These cluster means are descriptive, and none of the underlying item differences was significant.

The distributions in Figure 4 show the same pattern. Composite scores overlap heavily across conditions, the three medians fall within about half a scale point of one another, and the interquartile ranges largely overlap. There is no visible cluster of strongly affected respondents in either luxury condition, although a sample of this size could not reliably detect a small responsive subgroup.

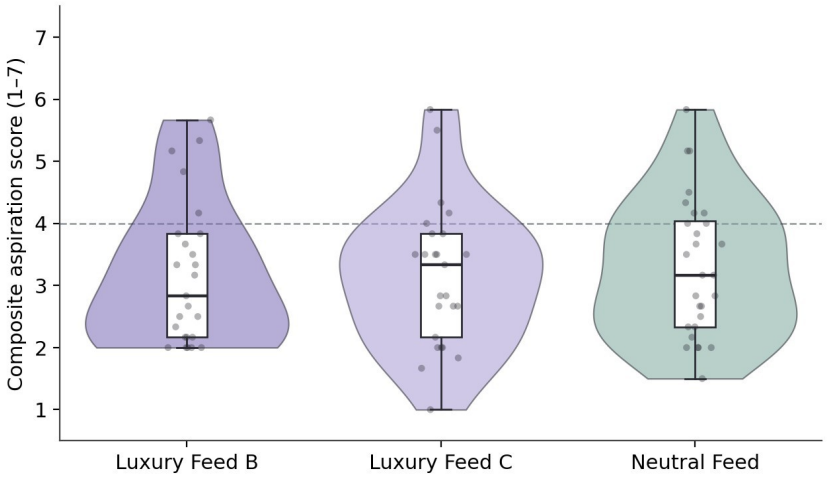


Figure 4. Distribution of composite scores by condition (violin plots with box plots and individual responses). The dashed line marks the scale midpoint.

5.4 Prior luxury interest does not predict post-exposure ratings

Another possibility is that prior luxury interest, and not the feed, drives post-exposure ratings. The data show little sign of that either. Pre-existing luxury interest was essentially uncorrelated with the post-exposure composite, $r = -.07$, $p = .56$, accounting for under one percent of the variance. In an OLS regression predicting the composite from pre-exposure interest and condition (pooled luxury versus neutral), neither predictor was significant (interest: $b = -0.05$, $p = .56$; treatment: $b = -0.14$, $p = .62$; model $R^2 = .008$). Knowing which feed a participant saw, or how interested in luxury they were beforehand, says almost nothing about their post-exposure ratings. This model tested main effects only. The narrower idea that exposure works only on people already drawn to luxury would require an interest-by-condition interaction, which a sample of this size cannot estimate with useful precision.

5.5 What the null result can and cannot rule out

A non-significant result is not, on its own, evidence that an effect is absent. Two further analyses examine which effect sizes the data can exclude (Figure 5).

Sensitivity power. With 50 participants in the pooled luxury conditions and 28 in the control, the planned contrast had 80% power (two-tailed, $\alpha = .05$) only for effects of $d \geq 0.67$, about 0.76 points on the 7-point scale. Its power was about 13% for a small effect ($d = 0.20$) and about 55% for a medium one ($d = 0.50$).

For the three-group ANOVA, 80% power required an effect of Cohen's $f \geq 0.36$, between the conventional medium (0.25) and large (0.40) benchmarks (Cohen, 1988). The study was well placed to detect a large effect of a single exposure and poorly placed to detect a small one.

Equivalence. The equivalence test asks whether the true effect is reliably smaller than a chosen bound, and it uses the 90% confidence interval, here $d = -0.12$, 90% CI [−0.51, 0.27]. Equivalence within the conventional small-effect bounds of ±0.20 was not established, $p = .37$, so the data cannot rule out a small effect in either direction. Equivalence within ±0.50 narrowly missed significance, $p = .055$; the tightest symmetric bound the data support is about ±0.51. Because the shaping hypothesis predicts a specific direction, the one-sided test is also informative. The data reject a luxury advantage of $d = 0.30$ or larger, $p = .040$, but not one of $d = 0.20$, $p = .090$.

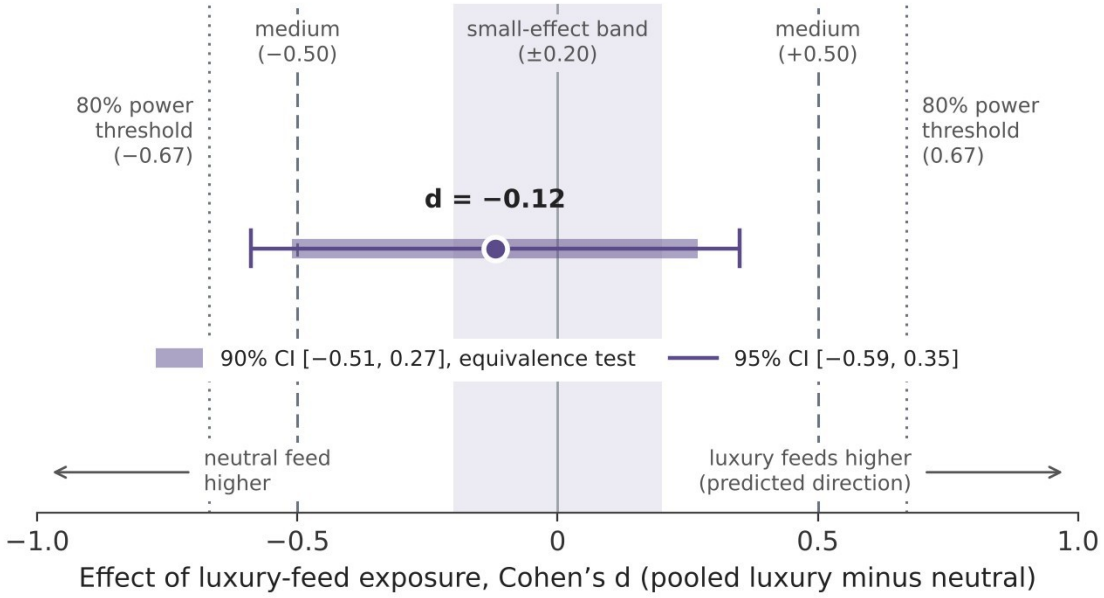


Figure 5. Estimated effect of luxury-feed exposure (pooled luxury minus neutral) in Cohen's d, with the 90% confidence interval used for the equivalence test (thick bar) and the 95% confidence interval (thin line). The shaded band marks the conventional small-effect bounds (±0.20), dashed lines mark ±0.50, and dotted lines mark the smallest effect the study could detect with 80% power (±0.67). The interval excludes large effects but not small ones.

These results support a precise but limited conclusion. One brief exposure to these curated luxury feeds produced no statistically detectable effect, and the data are inconsistent with a large effect or with a moderate one in the predicted direction. They do not establish practical equivalence at the small-effect level. A small effect of a single exposure remains possible, and detecting one with 80% power would take roughly 400 participants per condition.

5.6 Exploratory analysis: gender

As a secondary, exploratory analysis, composite scores were compared across gender groups, excluding the two respondents who did not disclose gender. Scores differed, $F(2, 73) = 3.58$, $p = .033$. Female respondents had the lowest composite ($M = 2.98$, $n = 53$), with male ($M = 3.62$, $n = 15$) and non-binary or

third-gender respondents (M = 3.85, n = 8) scoring higher (Figure 6). This result needs to be read cautiously. The male and non-binary groups are small, the comparison sits outside the experimental question, and the difference does not survive a Bonferroni correction for the seven secondary tests reported here (corrected α ≈ .007). Gender was not manipulated, so the comparison cannot support a causal or dispositional explanation, and the groups may also differ in age, country, or how they were recruited. The pattern is reported as a lead for future studies to test with larger, more balanced samples.

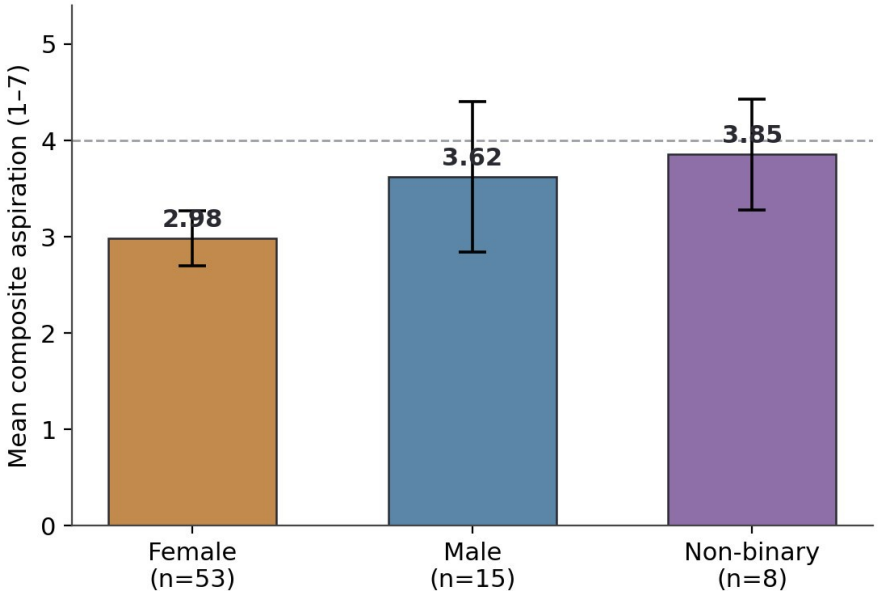


Figure 6. Exploratory comparison of mean composite scores by gender, with 95% confidence intervals. F(2, 73) = 3.58, p = .033, which is not significant after Bonferroni correction (α ≈ .007). The male and non-binary groups are small, so the pattern is tentative.

Across the omnibus test, the planned contrast, the six item-level tests, the distributions, and the regression, no analysis detected an effect of a single exposure to curated luxury content. That consistency is what a weak or absent short-run effect would produce, and it fits the account of slow taste formation in Section 2. The power and equivalence results mark its limits: they rule out a large effect but leave room for a small one, and none of these analyses tests the cumulative account itself.

6. Discussion: Implications for Luxury Markets and Culture

The null result reported here does not refute the literature, and it should not be read as showing that social media has no effect on luxury taste. What it does is narrow the claim. In this sample, one brief look at a curated luxury feed produced no detectable shift in luxury taste. If social media does shape luxury taste among young consumers, as much of the literature argues, repeated exposure over time is the more plausible route. The present data are consistent with that possibility but did not test it, and the implications below are framed accordingly.

6.1 Reconciling the null with the observational evidence

Prior studies associate social media engagement and influencer exposure with luxury purchase intention (Nallasivam et al., 2025; Sun et al., 2022), and interview studies describe young people learning luxury through social media (Park & Chun, 2025). This experiment found no detectable effect of a single

exposure. Both can be true at once if taste forms through accumulation: years of repeated contact could build the durable disposition that observational studies detect, while a single increment of exposure, the unit this experiment isolates, is too small to register. A second explanation fits the evidence just as well. The associations in observational studies may partly reflect self-selection, with people who already value luxury seeking out more luxury content. This study rules out neither account. What it does show is that the immediate version of the shaping claim found no support here, which strengthens the case for testing the observational literature's causal reading directly and over time.

6.2 Implications for luxury brand strategy

For brands, the results offer a cautious lesson. In this sample, a single brief exposure to curated luxury content did not shift how young adults rated luxury. If influence builds through accumulation, as the cumulative account proposes, a single sponsored placement or one viral post would be unlikely to change on its own how a young consumer values a brand, and sustained, repeated presence would matter more. Metrics that reward single-post reach could then misjudge true influence. These points are inferences from a null result in one small sample of 78 young adults, mostly Indian and mostly female, and they are better treated as hypotheses for brands to test than as established guidance. The exploratory gender pattern is too fragile to support conclusions about audience targeting.

6.3 Implications for influencer marketing

The literature finds that peers and relatable influencers drive Gen Z fashion and luxury consumption more than celebrities do (Sun et al., 2022; Fadiora, 2024). The cumulative account would extend this: influencer impact may build through an ongoing relationship and repeated exposure more than through any single endorsement. A one-time influencer post is, in effect, a single exposure, and this study found no detectable effect of a single exposure to curated luxury content. Whether sustained parasocial familiarity is what builds influence is a question for longitudinal research, and the present study cannot answer it.

6.4 Cultural and ethical implications: consumer autonomy reconsidered

There is a more reassuring cultural reading as well. A common anxiety holds that algorithms can manufacture desire almost instantly, overriding individual autonomy with a few well-targeted images. This study offers modest evidence against the strongest version of that fear: in this sample, a single curated luxury feed did not detectably change what young adults aspired to. The cumulative account, if correct, cuts the other way. Influence built slowly through months of immersion may be harder to notice and resist precisely because no single moment feels persuasive. The ethical concern would then shift from the persuasive power of any one feed to the compounding influence of the environment as a whole, which is a harder target for both regulation and personal awareness. Whether algorithmic personalization narrows taste diversity or entrenches elite aesthetics is a question only long-run evidence can settle.

7. Limitations and Future Research

The central limitation comes from the same feature that makes the design informative. By isolating a single exposure, the study cannot speak to the cumulative process discussed in Section 6. It can show that one exposure produced no detectable effect, but it cannot observe taste being built over time. Several further limitations qualify the findings.

- Single-session design. The study captures one brief exposure in an online survey. The cumulative hypothesis it motivates is untested here and needs to be examined longitudinally.
- Simulated, non-adaptive feeds. The feeds were static images curated by the researcher. They lacked the personalization and engagement loops of a real algorithmic environment, the features the theory says do the cumulative work, so the results concern exposure to curated content and not the effect of a platform algorithm.
- Uncontrolled exposure and no manipulation check. Viewing was self-paced and viewing time was not recorded, so participants may have differed in how long and how closely they looked at the feed. No manipulation check confirmed that participants perceived the luxury feeds as more luxury-oriented than the neutral feed. Future studies should record exposure time, set a minimum viewing duration, and include a manipulation check.
- Statistical power. With 78 participants, split 50 and 28 in the planned contrast, the study had 80% power only for effects of about $d = 0.67$ or larger. It can rule out large effects, and moderate effects in the predicted direction, but not small ones (Section 5.5).
- Sample and generalizability. The sample was a small online convenience sample of adults aged 18 to 28, mostly living in India and 68% female. It does not represent Generation Z as a whole, which spans many countries and includes people under 18, and the findings apply most directly to young, digitally active adults like those sampled. The male and non-binary subgroups were also small.
- Measurement. The six outcome items were developed for this study and have not been validated elsewhere. Three of them refer to the feed itself and therefore to different content across conditions. The outcome items were also anchored in the opposite direction from the baseline items (1 = strongly agree), which may have confused some respondents; scores were reverse- coded before analysis, but careless responses to the switch cannot be ruled out.
- Self-report and demand characteristics. Aspiration was measured by self-report immediately after exposure, which may capture stated rather than internalized attitudes and is vulnerable to demand effects.
- Immediate measurement only. Outcomes were assessed right after exposure, so any delayed or sleeper effects would not be captured.
- Ethics procedures. The study was reviewed by the program mentor and not by a formal ethics board, and the form had no explicit age screen or consent item. No participant was under 18, but future data collection should include both.

These limitations chart the path forward. First and most important, future research should adopt longitudinal or repeated-exposure designs that track the same participants across days or weeks of curated exposure, the direct test of the cumulative claim that this study can only motivate. Second, work using platform-level or behavioral data, such as real engagement logs in place of self-report, would capture the adaptive dynamics that a single simulated exposure cannot. Third, larger and more culturally diverse samples are needed; detecting a small single-exposure effect of $d = 0.20$ with 80% power would take roughly 400 participants per condition. Together, these directions would move the field from showing that algorithms matter toward demonstrating, at the level of mechanism and over the timescale that applies, how they build luxury taste.

8. Conclusion

This study set out to test a claim that much of the digital consumer culture literature asserts but rarely isolates: that curated luxury content on social media shapes young people's luxury taste. Using a randomized experiment with a neutral control, the counterfactual the observational literature lacks, it found that a single brief exposure to a simulated luxury feed produced no detectable increase in aspiration, normalization, identification, or purchase intention relative to a neutral feed, $F(2, 75) = 0.13$, $p = .88$, $d = -0.12$. The result held across the composite, every individual item, the full distribution, and a regression including prior luxury interest. Power and equivalence analyses show that the study can rule out a large effect, and a moderate one in the predicted direction, but not a small one.

The conclusion is not that algorithms are powerless. The study did not test a recommendation algorithm, and it observed a single exposure in one small, mostly Indian sample of young adults. What it shows is that the immediate, single-exposure version of the shaping claim found no support here. If social media does shape luxury taste, the most plausible remaining route is accumulation through repeated exposure over time. That hypothesis is consistent with theories of taste as a durable disposition and with the observational evidence, but this study did not test it. Testing it directly, with longitudinal designs and larger, more diverse samples, is the clear next step.

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